CHAPTER 14

OH JIMMY, JIMMY

22 February 2003

ENGLAND vs PAKISTAN, 2003 Cricket World Cup, *Cape Town*

England 246/8; Pakistan 134 all out

England won by 112 runs

Pakistan innings: **J Anderson 10–2–29–4**

The England team travel straight from Australia to South Africa for the World Cup. I'm selected and have travelled straight there with them. It feels like I've just been scooped up, caught in the momentum of a chaotic dream. In the England team, things are organised for you. Hotels are nicer, no one is sharing. You are bundled into buses and planes and cricket grounds and hotels and meeting rooms; all wearing the same thing. As we travel, I find myself suddenly with better-fitting kit, a number – 40 – and my name on the shirt too. It's tempting to never take it off when I get back to the hotel room. Just to process, this is real, this is actually happening to me. It is so many things at once – like living out a fantasy and a sort of nervous nightmare too. I am in the team for the World Cup, scratching my head and looking through the names and wondering if that means I am actually in England's best XI, mumbling my way through the days, silently sitting there, watching and rubbing my eyes at all these players who were heroes to me until so recently, being in my space, my teammates.

Cape Town is beautiful, but on the drive from the airport to the cricket ground, there are lots of townships. It's like travelling through different worlds, in a very short space of time. I'm beginning to grow accustomed to that. The ground there is one of the most stunning in the world – the stands